

How to use Office Hours and Piazza?

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Remarks on this document

- This document is heavily based on a template provided by (and is also motivated by) a wonderful instructor, a former postdoc in UW–Madison, Dr. Boya Wen. Thanks Dr. Wen!
- In what follows, questions are from the perspective of students, and answers are from the perspective of the instructor. Switch what “I” or “you” means accordingly.

Office hour FAQs:

Q0: When and where do we have office hours?

A0: Please see Course Overview <https://canvas.wisc.edu/courses/488842> for office hour schedules and location.

Q1: What are office hours?

A1: Office hours are a time that instructors set aside to be available to students. They are called “office hours” because, traditionally, students can find the instructor during this time in the instructor’s office. But this semester I am holding my “office hours” in the Math Learning Center space, at Van Vleck B224 upper level.

Q2: Do I need to let you know before coming to office hours?

A2: No. Anyone in my class can come to my office hours and Course Assistant’s office hours and we don’t need to know ahead of time. We will be available during the whole time set for office hours and you can come and go any time during the time slot. If you cannot make it to the office hours due to scheduling conflicts, then you can post a question on Piazza (for non-confidential questions including all math questions), or email me (for confidential questions).

Q3: What can I ask during office hours? Can I ask for help on homework assignments?

A3: You can ask anything concerning the course materials, including (but certainly not limited to) homework questions! Other examples including questions about a concept/result/argument/example/exercise in class, practice problems, problems from an exam, questions when reading the textbook, etc.

Q4: Can I still come to office hours if I don't have a concrete question in mind?

A4: Yes, absolutely! There are many other ways you can benefit from office hours. For example, it is very common to feel so confused about a topic that you don't know how to formulate your questions precisely. I've been there, too. I'd appreciate it if you could share with me as early as possible when this happens. Office hours are a great place for us to work together and locate more precisely where you are confused, and then work on it. You can also come to office hours and listen to what others have to ask, and join discussions in office hours.

Q5: How do you work with students in office hours?

A5: You will soon find out that I seldom reply to your questions with the answer; I am always interested in what you have tried. It will almost always be a conversation, and by participating in the conversation actively, you will help me understand how you think about the problem and help me find a way to best assist you in your learning. Once we locate where you are stuck, I'll zoom in to the problem and break it down a little more or give you some hint on other things to try. Some students may find it stressful, especially when I ask some questions back to help identify the problem. I try my best to make my office hours (and classes) to be a safe space where you can ask questions, struggle, and be confused without feeling judged. Struggling is a valuable part of learning, though I know it can be uncomfortable. You can also tell me how you feel about my way of working with you, and I will adjust accordingly, but I will always expect your active participation in some way.

Q6: Do I need to prepare for office hours?

A6: In light of Q4, please don't feel unprepared stop you from coming to office hours. If you are ever debating whether to come to an office hour and feel you should be more prepared to come, I would encourage you not to wait until next time but come this time. It is my responsibility to help you in a nonjudgmental way regardless of where you are in your learning process. However, we are likely to proceed much further within limited time if you have put efforts into formulating a question and working on it.

Piazza FAQs:

Q1: What can I ask on our course Piazza page?

A1: Anything related to the course and not concerning your own private information. You are particularly encouraged to ask questions related to the course material.

Q2: Can I answer questions on Piazza?

A2: Yes, please! You can answer a question using "followup discussions" on a Piazza post.

Q3: Can I ask questions anonymously?

A3: You can choose to be anonymous to your classmates or not, but your name will always show up

on the instructors' end.

Q4: When should I use private posting (visible to instructors)?

A4: A good example is when you want to include a picture of your private information (e.g., names, grades, etc). For more confidential information you are encouraged to email me (hhong78@wisc.edu) directly. For general questions that do not involve your information, please post to the entire class so that the instruction team do not need to answer similar questions repeatedly.

Q5: Will you check Piazza and answer questions?

A5: Yes! I will check Piazza about (at least) once per 48h. During the time I'm on Piazza, I read through questions, student's answers, and follow-up, and add my input by writing an instructor's answer, writing a follow-up, or clicking "good answer."

Q6: What should I pay attention to when using Piazza?

A6: Please be respectful and professional. It takes our joint effort to make Piazza (and classes, and office hours) a safe space for everyone to ask questions and express confusion and struggle.

If you have other concerns about these topics, please do not hesitate to let me know on Piazza (if it isn't a personal concern), over email (if it is a personal concern).